

Know Your Bones: Understanding Osteoporosis and Protecting Your Bone Health

Osteoporosis is a common condition that weakens bones and makes them more prone to fractures. As bone density decreases, even minor falls or everyday movements can lead to breaks—most often in the spine, hips, and wrists. Although osteoporosis can affect anyone, it is especially common in women, particularly after menopause. In fact, about half of women over age 50 will experience an osteoporosis-related fracture during their lifetime.

A major reason women are at higher risk after menopause is the steep drop in estrogen, a hormone essential for maintaining strong bones. During the first five to seven years after menopause, women may lose up to 20% of their bone mass. Osteoporosis develops when too much old bone is broken down or when the body cannot rebuild bone fast enough to replace what is lost.

Good nutrition, physical activity, and healthy lifestyle habits play a crucial role in protecting bone health. Bones need specific vitamins and minerals to stay strong, including calcium, vitamin D, magnesium, phosphorus, and vitamin K. Eating at least two servings of calcium-rich foods daily—such as dairy products, leafy greens, or calcium-fortified foods—helps support bone strength. Vitamin D is equally important, because it helps the body absorb calcium. Sun exposure, certain foods, and supplements can help maintain healthy vitamin D levels.

Regular exercise also supports bone health. Weight-bearing activities like walking, dancing, and strength training stimulate bone formation and help slow bone loss. Most adults should aim for 30 minutes of physical activity most days of the week. Lifestyle choices matter, too—avoiding smoking and limiting alcohol can significantly reduce the risk of fractures.

For some people, supplements may be necessary, particularly if dietary intake of calcium or vitamin D is insufficient. A healthcare provider can help determine if supplements, bone density testing, or medical treatment are appropriate. Early prevention and routine monitoring can make a meaningful difference in maintaining lifelong bone strength.

Bone Health Checklist

Use this quick checklist to support strong bones every day.

Daily

- ☐ Ate 2+ servings of calcium-rich foods
- ☐ Got sunlight or took vitamin D
- ☐ Included nutrient-rich foods (magnesium, vitamin K, phosphorus)
- ☐ Avoided smoking
- ☐ Limited alcohol

Weekly

- ☐ Completed strength training 2–3 times
- ☐ Did weight-bearing activity 3–5 days
- ☐ Prepared bone-healthy meals

Long-Term

- ☐ Discussed bone health with my doctor
- ☐ Know whether I need a bone density test
- ☐ Reviewed supplements or treatment options